and thereby humiliate his nephew, who was becoming an increasingly unwelcome presence. For there was no stronger reminder of the threat that Humayun posed than his son, Akbar and Kamran therefore did not look upon Akbar with favour and was hoping he would be shown his place by Mirza Ibrahim. To the utter discomfiture of Kamran, on this occasion, the two-and-a-half-year-old Akbar grabbed his older cousin by the waist, lifted him up, and threw him to the ground. When Akbar strode around beating the little kettledrum, to the amusement of his indulgent servants, Kamran, in a fit of petulance, ordered the child to be weaned immediately. While this may appear to us to be relatively old for a child to be weaned, it was quite the custom for children then to be suckled till the age of five. Moreover, Kamran would have been depriving the motherless Akbar of the comfort of his milk mothers. What was surprising, however, was the boisterous strength and confidence of the child Akbar, traits which would survive into adulthood, much magnified.

As Humayun marched back to reclaim his empire, he first seized Kandahar where he defeated Askari. Askari would eventually be exiled to Mecca, where he would die. Hindal, youngest of Humayun's brothers, came over to the Padshah's camp and Humayun finally marched towards Kabul and Kamran deserted the city. Heralded by drummers, Humayun rode into the city in November 1544 in the middle of the night and Akbar was finally reunited with his grateful father. 'Merely to look at him,' wrote Gulbadan about Humayun, 'eased the sorrow-stricken heart.' Another woman was added to the Mughal household when Humayun took a new wife, a woman named Mah-chuchak Begum, who would bear him four daughters and two sons over the next ten years. There were also two new additions Humayun brought back with him from Persia who would alter the artistic landscape of Hindustan forever.

Shah Tahmasp, though he had enjoyed a robust, libertine adolescence, had recently gone through a phase of tawba, or repentance. Though still only in his twenties, a young man with penetrating eyes and a luxurious auburn beard, he had banned alcohol, gambling, prostitution and, to Hindustani arts' eternal gratitude, painting, from his realm. So a short while after his arrival at Kabul, Humayun was able to send invitations to two Persian painters, Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd al-Samad, whom Shah Tahmasp would release from his own ateliers. According to legend, Mir Sayyid Ali had impressed the Mughal Padshah with the admittedly awe-inspiring skill